high-ranking government officials. According to Tibetan sources, the conference was an opportunity the Tibetan government did not want to miss. They wanted recognition for their declaration of independence, and Lönchen Shatra and his men had collected documents in support of their case, which they presented before the British and Chinese representatives.[11]

China's main delegate was Chen Yifan, or Ivan Chen, a widely travelled diplomat who was fluent in English and had served for nine years in the Chinese Legation in London as counsellor. Designated as commissioner for Tibet, Chen was assisted by deputy commissioner Wang Haiping. But the power behind Chen and Wang was Lu Xingqi (Lu Hsing-chi), a more powerful officer who had played a crucial role in fostering divisions between the Dalai Lama and the second-most important lama in Tibet, the Panchen Lama, after the former had returned to Lhasa in 1912.[12]

In April 1913, the Chinese government had appointed Lu commissioner for Tibet. He was then ordered to leave for Tibet by sea via Kolkata. Lu was unable to proceed from there to Tibet and had to remain in the Indian city, which he knew quite well. At some time in the late nineteenth century, he had gone to Kolkata to study at a local Chinese school and later started a company called Tianyi Gongsi. Located in Tiretta Bazar in the city's Chinatown, it did business in fur imported from Tibet.[13]

Apart from being a successful businessman, Lu was all along an intelligence operative charged with Indian and Tibetan affairs.[14] Chen became the new, official face of the Chinese government for Tibetan affairs, although Chinese sources do not state when the post was shifted to him from Lu, if that happened at all officially.[15] Lu stayed in constant contact with Chen and the Chinese government throughout the proceedings in Shimla.

The conference ran into serious problems from the very beginning, as the Chinese wanted Tibet to be referred to as an integral part of China. Lönchen Shatra had hardly ever left his native land, but surprised the British and Chinese delegates with his grasp of political affairs as he presented his claims—and contradicted Chen's version or Tibet's status. Lönchen Shatra outlined the Chinese excesses during the 1910–12 occupation and, not surprisingly, continued to press for recognition of an independent Tibet: